

Tackling Pakistan SOME SUCCESS

But India dare not let up on the pressure

A year after 26/11, it has been a mixed bag for India when it comes to tackling Pakistan diplomatically. After countless note verbales and diplomatic notes have been exchanged between the two countries on the Mumbai 26/11 attacks, and reams of pages in seven diplomatic dossiers traded between the two neighbours, there is a sense of déjà vu on India's relationship with Pakistan.

India blames Pakistan for terrorist acts, and Pakistan promises action, but there is no change of heart. Another terror attack happens and the story gets repeated yet again. While the culprits of 26/11 are yet to be punished, key conspirators like Hafeez Mohammed Saeed, who has been chargesheeted by India, roam freely in Pakistan. As fresh revelations emerge from the interrogation of David Headley and Tahawwur Hussain Rana, there are leads that the trail of 26/11 may well lead to state actors in Pakistan.

The Mumbai attack itself was a game changer in some ways and drew international support for India. As calls for action grew, the UN put Jamaat-ud-Dawa on its terror blacklist in December 2008. A month later, Islamabad conceded that the plot was hatched on its territory and that Pakistan-based terror group Lashkar-e-Toiba was involved. While this is more than what Pakistan had ever conceded and was a step-up for India, given Pakistan's track record, there was enough drama in the diplomatic script.

As India upped pressure through its dossier diplomacy at frequent intervals to put pressure on Pakistan, the strategy worked. While India is all set to conclude the 26/11 trial soon with the Mumbai court issuing non-bailable warrants against the 27 accused who are now absconding, including LeT founder Saeed, Islamabad diluted the case hiding behind the recent terror attacks. The case has been adjourned several times and three judges have been changed. Though a fresh date for hearing has been set for December while Zakiur Rehman Lakhvi and Zarar Shah are being tried, there are no charges against Saeed. This gives little assurance that 26/11 victims will get justice.

WHAT'S DONE

■ **Pressure on Pakistan saw it admit that attacks planned and executed from its territory**

■ **Engaged international interlocutors to turn the heat**

■ **Dossier diplomacy put Pakistan on notice**

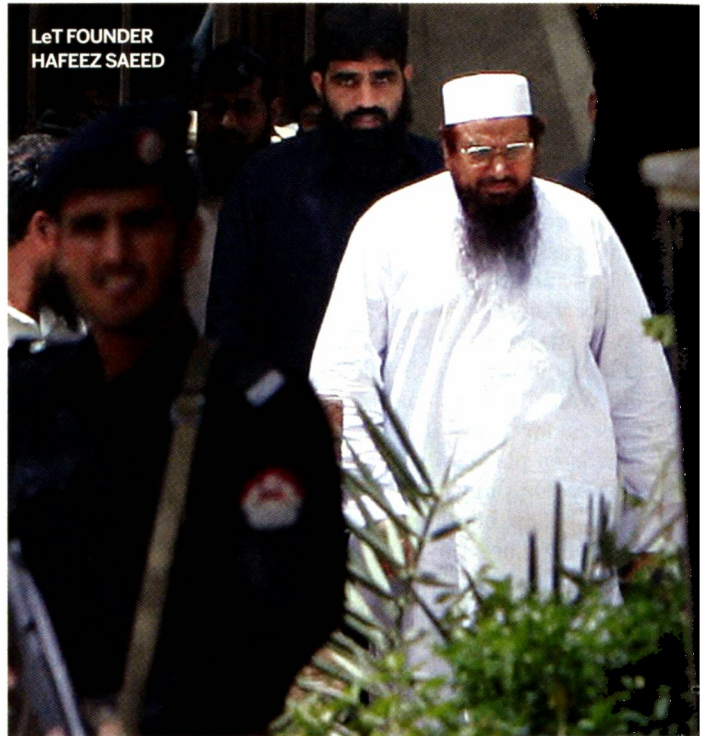
WHAT'S NOT

■ **Not been able to force Pakistan to expedite 26/11 trial**

■ **Big fish like Hafeez Saeed still free**

■ **Focussed approach on terror missing**

AP PHOTO/K M CHAUDHARY



Frustration is setting in India and as Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao says: "We are concerned at the slow and tardy action against those responsible for the Mumbai attacks." But what should be the Indian strategy now? While India should continue with its policy on no composite dialogue, it should engage with Pakistan with the limited

agenda of terrorism and getting the 26/11 guilty punished should be a sustained campaign. Then, along with international interlocutors like the US, India should insist that a segmented approach is harming the fight against terror and that rogue elements in the Pakistan Army and the ISI would have to be effectively neutralised. A recalcitrant Pakistan will never address India's terror concerns till it realises that it will have to pay a heavy cost if it continues to perpetuate terror. While diplomacy should be the soft cushion, India should strive to work on a policy of multiple options with Pakistan. If this can be sustained, it could be a turning point for India's Pakistan policy.

by Saurabh Shukla

INDIA'S MOST WANTED

HAFEEZ MOHAMMED SAEED: Founder and supreme leader of the LeT. Met and motivated the 26/11 attackers.

ZAKI-UR-REHMAN LAKHVI: The LeT's military commander planned and masterminded the attacks

ZARAR SHAH: Communications chief, who kept in touch with the 26/11 attackers.

COL. R. SAADATULLAH: of the Pakistan Army's special Communications Organisation. Arranged telephonic links between the LeT leaders and attackers.

Pakistan will never address India's concerns till it realises that it will have to pay a price.